

His people and we had better get about the business of eliminating debt immediately, or Romans 13:8 doesn't mean that Christians should never borrow anything.

So I did some evaluation of the passage in Romans. I'd like to share my conclusions, because I believe they are accurate and confirmed by the preponderance of Scripture. You can read the same passages and make up your own mind. Just bear in mind that when I began my study I was looking for a justification of the teaching that all borrowing is unscriptural.

To understand Romans 13:8, it is necessary to go back to Romans 13:6, where Paul discusses the payment of taxes. Christians in Paul's day often took the position that they should not have to pay taxes to the government of Rome because it was a heathen government. Paul admonished the believers, saying that as Roman subjects they were to obey the laws regarding taxes. I'm sure that when he did this, he was keeping in mind the Lord's discussion of taxes in Matthew 22:17–21 and that he believed that it was unscriptural for Christians to refuse to pay their taxes. Paul expanded and restated his instructions concerning the payment of taxes: "Give everyone what you owe him: If you owe taxes, pay taxes; if revenue, then revenue; if respect, then respect; if honor, then honor" (Romans 13:7).

With the background of verses 6 and 7 in mind, in Paul's directive to Christians to "let no debt remain outstanding," "no debt" takes on a different significance than it might if it were read in isolation. Paul was summing up the legally prescribed duty all men had to pay their taxes and to respect government officials. He was not giving a new teaching on the subject of borrowing money but, rather, was reconfirming a previous admonition to obey the law. Thus we can say that although borrowing is not promoted scripturally, it is not prohibited.

BIBLICAL PRINCIPLES OF BORROWING

Principles of borrowing appear in God's Word, although it needs to be remembered that these are principles, not laws. From time to